

Fruits of a wild tomato, from Mexico

Wild tomato flowers

Cultivated tomato flowers are very similar

Cultivated tomatoes

Cultivated tomatoes have become much bigger through breeding

BIGGER—AND BETTER?
The tomato's wild ancestor is a red berry the size of a small grape. It is much sweeter than a modern tomato, with a stronger flavor.

GROWING IN WATER

Rice, which was cultivated in the Far East at least 5,000 years ago, forms the staple cereal diet of over one half of the world's population. It usually grows in fields of standing water, known as paddy fields.

Flower head of wild carrot

Wild carrot root

Working in the paddy fields

Cultivated carrot

EDIBLE ROOTS

The wild carrot is found all over Europe and through much of Asia, but its roots are white or only slightly colored. Only in Afghanistan is there a variety of wild carrot with orange roots. The carrot was probably first cultivated in that region, and then introduced to other parts of the world.

Wild cabbage has dark green, leathery leaves

LEAVING THE PAST BEHIND
The wild cabbage grows near the sea. It has leathery leaves, loosely arranged on a branched stem. Years of breeding have gotten rid of the plant's bitter taste and made its leaves more juicy. The shape of the plant has also changed so that, in most cultivated cabbages, the leaves are packed tightly together. In red cabbage varieties, certain natural pigments have been built up as a result of selective breeding.

Modern cabbage

Modern red cabbage

CARROTS AND CABBAGES

This detail from a 16th-century painting by the Dutch artist Lucas Van Valkenborch proves that even 400 years ago there was a wide variety of vegetables available.